



History of LEGO

Beginnings

In 1916, Danish carpenter Ole Kirk Kristiansen bought a woodwork workshop to build furniture and house supplies in. However, following the world-wide Great Depression of the 1930s, there was a huge decline in demand for housing and furniture and he realised he needed to diversify in order to save his business, so he decided to make wooden toys for children. He started making alphabet building blocks, wooden yoyos and hand-painted pull-along toys.

A game changing move, in 1947, was Kristiansen's purchase of a plastic-injection moulding machine which allowed for superior detail in the design. By 1949 he was producing Automatic Binding Blocks, which we now know as LEGO.

Awesome Combinations

LEGO can be put together in a staggering number of ways. If you have two eight-stud LEGO bricks you can combine these in a remarkable 24 ways. Add one more brick and the possibilities go up to 1,060! If you have six eight-stud bricks, you can combine them in an astounding 915,103,765 ways! The possibilities are staggering.

Taken from *The LEGO Book* by Daniel Lipkowitz.

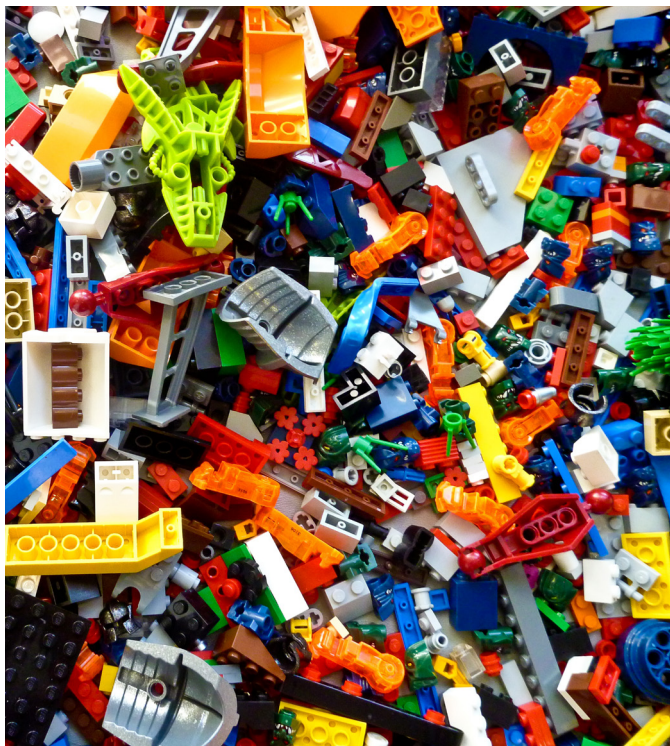
What's in a Name?

To decide on a name, Kristiansen ran a competition offering a bottle of wine to whichever worker chose the best one. In the end, he kept the prize himself, settling on LEGO, a shortened version of 'Leg Godt': Danish for 'play well'. It is also a Latin verb meaning 'to assemble' or 'put together'.

Building with Bricks

It was Godtfred Kirk Kristiansen, Ole Kirk's son, who, in 1954, presented an innovative new idea: a system of play. This would enable every element to connect to every other element. He wanted to create 'a toy that prepares the child for life, appeals to the imagination, and develops the creative urge and joy of creation that are the driving force in every human being.'

By 1955, the LEGO system of play had launched with everything children needed to create their own town centre and, by 1957, a new brick had been developed. This was patented in 1958 and has now been registered in over 33 countries. Even though LEGO bricks are manufactured in hundreds of different shapes and sizes, every single one of them connects to the original two stud by four stud brick.



Amazing Numbers

19 billion LEGO bricks are produced worldwide every year. That's 36,000 every minute!

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Mini Delights: Facts About Mini-Figures

- Invented 1978
- 1½ inches tall
- More than 2,500 different characters
- Yoda is the smallest character due to his shorter legs
- Other short-legged figures include goblins and other film characters

